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CALIFORNIA BECOMES FIRST STATE TO CREATE AN OFFICIAL STATE SEAL FOR NON-ULTRAPROCESSED FOODS

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SACRAMENTO, Calif., Sept. 28 -- The California State Assembly Democratic Caucus issued the following news release:

LOS ANGELES, CA -Help is on the way for millions of California families trying to decode ingredient lists on packaged foods. At a bill signing ceremony at UCLA Mattel Children's Hospital, California Governor Gavin Newsom signed Assembly Bill (AB) 2244, landmark legislation that will empower Californians to make better informed and healthier choices by increasing transparency around ultra-processed foods. Authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), AB 2244 establishes the first-ever "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" seal that food manufacturers can place on products that meet clear standards for not being ultra-processed. Modeled after the widely recognized "USDA Organic" label, the seal will provide consumers with a simple, trustworthy way to identify healthier options with a quick glance. The bill also will require grocery stores in California to prominently display products bearing the "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" seal, thereby making it easier for busy families to find healthier foods quickly and conveniently.

"While Washington D.C. is paralyzed by inaction, Republicans and Democrats in California are joining forces to empower consumers to avoid harmful ultra-processed foods," saidAssemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino). "Like the USDA Organic label, this new seal will provide consumers with clear, trustworthy information and make it easier for them to locate healthier foods that are free from harmful additives. Parents shouldn't need a Ph.D. in chemistry to understand what they're feeding their kids. California began this movement three years ago by banning the most dangerous food additives, and with Governor Newsom's continued leadership we are taking another big step forward today."

Building on California's Track Record as the National Leader on Food Safety

AB 2244 is the latest in a series of Gabriel-authored laws that have reshaped how California - and increasingly the country - thinks about what's in our food. Last year, Assemblymember Gabriel authored and Governor Newsom signed into lawThe Real Food, Healthy Kids Act (AB 1264, 2025), groundbreaking legislation which established the nation's first statutory definition of ultra-processed foods and set up a process to ban harmful products from California schools. Assemblymember Gabriel also successfully passed into law two other landmark bills with bipartisan support: theCalifornia Food Safety Act (AB 418, 2023) and theCalifornia School Food Safety Act (AB 2316, 2024). Collectively, these laws have helped change the national conversation about food additives and ultra-processed foods, shaped federal policy, and inspired similar legislation across more than 30 other states.

The Science Behind the Seal

Research has increasingly linked high consumption of ultra-processed foods to serious health harms, including cancer, cardiovascular disease, Type 2 diabetes, metabolic disorders, reproductive harm, and other chronic conditions. Despite these risks, many consumers struggle to distinguish between minimally processed and highly processed products due to confusing labels and marketing practices.

AB 2244 addresses this challenge by creating a simple certification program that empowers consumers with clear, front-of-package information and improves access to healthier options through strategic in-store placement. Modeled after the successful and widely recognized "USDA Organic" label, this legislation establishes a process overseen by the California Department of Public Health (CDPH) where food manufacturers could apply to accredited certification agents to use the "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" label on their packaging, thereby indicating that a

product meets clear standards for not being ultra-processed. This seal reflects the same commonsense, market-based approach that made the USDA Organic label a success: give manufacturers a voluntary standard worth meeting, and let consumers do the rest.

A Broad and Bipartisan Coalition

AB 2244 passed the Legislature with support of a broad coalition that includes the Environmental Working Group, the California Medical Association, the American Academy of Pediatrics, the American Diabetes Association, the American Heart Association, the Crohn's & Colitis Foundation, and the United Nurses Associations of California. The bill passed with overwhelming bipartisan support with votes of 32-0 in the State Senate and 72-0 in the State Assembly.

Voices Behind the Seal: What Experts and Leaders Are Saying

"Once again, California is leading the way by helping consumers identify and avoid UPFs. Last year, California enacted the nation's first definition of UPFs. This week, California has taken the next step by helping consumers distinguish between processed foods, which are part of a healthy diet, and ultra processed foods, which are engineered to be overeaten. Our food should nourish us, not make us sick. EWG is so grateful that Assemblymember Gabriel is continuing to put our health first." - Melanie Benesh, Vice President of Government Affairs, Environmental Working Group

"It's clear that most Americans are concerned about ultra-processed foods and want to avoid them, but these products are so ubiquitous and heavily promoted that it's become exceedingly hard to do that. An easy-to-understand front-of-package label makes it so much easier for Californians to choose the non-ultra-processed options they want for their families. This is an important step towards a food supply that prioritizes whole, nourishing foods over industrially produced food products."- Alyssa J. Moran, ScD, MPH,Deputy Director, Center for Food and Nutrition Policy, University of Pennsylvania

"We have a long road ahead to a food supply free from harmful chemicals and a healthier America. In the meantime, we must give consumers the tools and knowledge to make healthier food choices. By creating a 'Non-Ultraprocessed Certified' seal to help identify healthier, non-UPF options, Assemblymember Gabriel and Governor Newsom continue to advance California's leadership in the fight to reduce consumption of the hyperpalatable, addictive ultra-processed foods driving our nation's chronic disease crisis." - Todd Wagner, entrepreneur and co-founder of FoodFight USA

(News Release; Media Release; Announcement; Press Briefing; Remarks; Congressional Documents; Court Order; Court Judgement; Judgment; Court Opinion; Federal Government; Local Government; State Government; Speech; Transcript, Notice, Notification)

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